



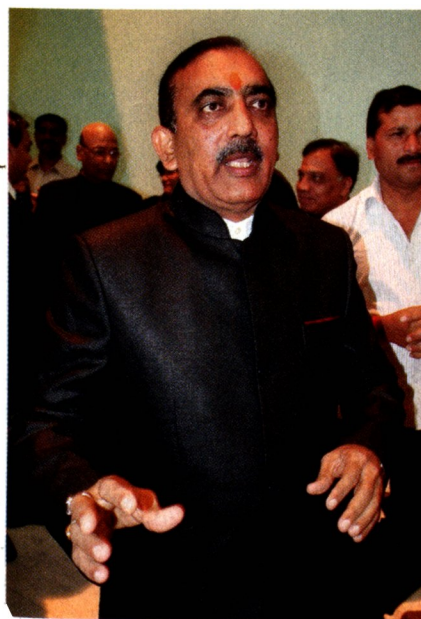
CLOCKWISE FROM LEFT: KAMAL PATEL, BRAJENDRA SINGH RATHORE, AND BHAIYA RAJA AND ASHA RANI SINGH

assembly segment in Tikamgarh district. In subsequent raids, huge cache of arms, ammunition and explosives, including illegal country-made guns, were seized from their residences. While Yashpal has a long criminal record, Rathore himself is an accused in another case of murder of a sarpanch. Retired IPS officer Arun Gurtu says, "Destruction of evidence and gagging of witnesses highlight the brazen and wilful disregard of the law by the political elite."

This cult of violence is promoted for financial windfalls like illegal mining. A case in point is the arrest of Kaptan Singh, the son of Congress MLA and former minister Aidal Singh Kansana, in Morena district earlier this month after he not only chased down a truck confiscated by the Forest Department for ferrying illegally mined sand from a forest area, but also wrested its control at gun-point.

While Madhya Pradesh's politics is still a duopoly of the BJP and the Congress, politicians from fringe outfits find it convenient to carve a political niche through violence. SP MLA in the last Vidhan Sabha, Kishore Samrite, was convicted in a case of arson and destruction of public property this year. Still more worrisome trend is the involvement of the leading politicians' progeny in criminal cases (see box). Former deputy advocate general Ajay Mishra, says, "When sons or nephews of politicians grow up seeing the police and administration genuflect before MLAs and ministers, you can't expect them to abide by the law."

While creating their own cult of violence, these politicians are creating personal patronage networks that operate outside the law. This reduces their reliance on traditional party structures to win elections. If denied tickets, many cross over to fringe parties, as witnessed on the eve of the 2008 assembly elections. If that becomes an exodus, the BJP and the Congress would both be political losers. The time for purge is now. ■



THE LAWBREAKERS

A growing number of kin of politicians are being accused of various crimes

- A liquor baron in Indore alleges that the son of Tribal Welfare Minister Kunwar Vijay Shah was behind the suicide of his daughter in 2008
- Monu Patel, nephew of former Union minister Prahlaad Patel, was externed from Narsinghpur district following registration of many cases
- An attempt-to-murder case was filed against Rajkumar, son of former BJP MLA Chhotelal Saraogi, in 2006 after he tried to run over the then collector of Shahdol district
- Former Khandwa MP Nand Kumar Singh Chauhan's son Harsh and nephew Sanjay were the accused in a murder case in 2007